

HERE COMES THE BILL

The closest I've come to my wedding was my bat mitzvah in 2001.

Throughout middle school, I attended a different bar or bat mitzvah party every weekend—sometimes twice a weekend. For these lavish parties, we not only had to buy expensive gifts for these new “adults,” we were also expected to buy a new dress for every party (which I definitely couldn't always afford to do, to my utmost mortification). It was abundantly clear who could afford to do all this and who couldn't. Bar mitzvahs became a “my super sweet sixteen” nightmare, a competition for which parent could throw the most outrageous party for their thirteen-year-old child. I attended bar and bat mitzvah parties on boats and in high-profile nightclubs in Miami. Parents hired well-known party planners for these events, and some of them featured huge chocolate fountains and ice luges.

By stark contrast, the non-wealthy kids had bar and bat mitzvah parties that were small or (gasp!) more focused on religion, or maybe they didn't have one at all. This period of my youth messed with me hard—and not just with me but with my mom too.

As I approached the end of seventh grade and my own bat mitzvah closed in on us, my mom felt guilty about not being able to give me a party that would impress everyone at school. In her desperation, relying on her signature “act now, think later” mentality, she planned one we could not afford.

It was outrageous.

My theme was “outer space.” The venue was decorated to look like a rocket. My centerpieces were spinning planets. We gave out personalized yarmulkes and apparel that said “Gabrielle's Galaxy.” We hired professional dancers who came dressed as aliens and astronauts. In short, it was way more than any thirteen-year-old should ever be allowed to have. When I asked her about it in 2016, my mom blamed “peer pressure,” and then she revealed the big number: My bat